



League Before CRICKET

THE DELHI DAREDEVILS AND
CHENNAI SUPER KINGS FIGHT IT
OUT ON A FOREIGN FIELD

South Africa gives the IPL a spectacular new stage and also a few home truths

By Sharda Ugra

Season 2 has just ended and for a little while, a phenomenon quite removed from the Indian Premier League (IPL) will prevail: silence. Think about it. Evenings free of Ravi Shastri hollering as if he has to make himself heard from South Africa to India minus the benefit of microphone or satellites.

But before that, to give due credit to the IPL (actually to get it out of the way before the self-congratulation breaks out) Season 2 turned absurdity into reality. At three weeks notice, an event involving 59 matches, eight

teams, 160-odd cricketers, 80 support staff and officials, was moved to another country, 7,860 km away. Barring a stray dog, a few malfunctioning floodlight towers and a mass attack of hyperventilation amongst TV commentators, the Indian cricket tamasha went smoothly into its final week in South Africa.

Flights were caught, hotel rooms found, matches held. The cricket entertained and to the eternal credit of the South Africans, every request, odd or unreasonable, was met. So what if the IPL first wanted all the hospitality suites and then couldn't fill them. So what if a cricketer wanted his room

number to only ever add up to the auspicious digit of five.

But the IPL's essential purpose is not to give travel agents anxiety attacks. It is because it sells. The event was set up to create a new revenue stream for Indian cricket and shake up the world of cricket. Its move to South Africa was expected to widen its audience but also to escalate costs.

Franchises still do not know by how much. At the end of the event they will be presented with a bill by the IPL which made all the arrangements in South Africa. An executive says, "We've lost revenue from tickets and local promotions. Our bill at

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